would have been well within his rights to abort the sortie. The urgency of the situation was such that he decided to land, displaying superb flying skills.

The arrival of the armour gave a major fillip to the Chushul defences. Western Command, now faced with the real problem of having to defend Leh, decided to induct nearly a division worth of troops into Ladakh mainly by milking the formations that were facing Pakistan. The IAF, while also dealing with a similar situation in Se-la in the east, was flying round the clock. At the same time, even the first line transport from units and formations was being withdrawn to form ad hoc motor companies to facilitate induction.

Also on 25 October, Brigadier R. S. Grewal, MC, arrived in Leh with 70 Infantry Brigade HQ and took over responsibility of the Indus Valley Sector on the same day. Major General Budh Singh officially raised 3 Infantry Division on 26 October 1962 at Leh. His mandate was the defence of Leh. 114 Infantry Brigade HQ, responsible for the Chushul and Phobrang Sectors, remained under the control of XV Corps.

THE DEMCHOK SECTOR

Originating close to the Manasarovar Lake in Tibet, the Indus flows eastwards, entering India to the northwest of Tashigang at 12,700 feet. Bound by the traditional Indo-Tibetan border to the north, east and south, its western flank is marked by a ridge that separates the waters of the Hanle from the various small streams that feed into the Indus. In this region, the Indus flows from the southeast to the northwest, through a valley that is fairly broad. To the north of this sector is the Chang Pass, to the northeast the Jara-la (both around 16,500 feet) and in the south the Charding-la (17,000 feet).

The Indus at this point is quite placid, languidly flowing along for 130 kilometres before entering the gorge beyond Mahe. The north bank of the river is a broad plain almost three kilometres in width while on the south bank the terrain is rockier. On both banks there were bridle paths that connected Tashigang with Leh. Indian Army vehicles used the southern bank where the ground was harder. At Fukche, there was a PSP airstrip that was used by the IAF to ferry supplies into the sector. Dungti was the main base, from where army Engineers had built a road to the north to link Chushul.